Group SupervisoR

Ashley Robertson & Holly Neill

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Overview

Welcome to our book on supervising dissertation projects in groups. Please feel free to use whatever you find useful, to pass on to others, and to adapt these resources to suit your own supervision style.

You can navigate to each of the chapters using the bar on the left hand side, or using the links below. Within each chapter, a breakdown of the main sections will be provided on the right hand side.

We have structured the book as follows:

- Chapter 1: About Us
- Chapter 2: Benefits (and challenges!) of Group Supervision
- Chapter 3: Getting Set up for the Year Ahead
- Chapter 4: Different Types of Supervision Sessions
- Chapter 5: Examples of Group Supervision Sessions
- Chapter 6: Employability and Transferable Skills
- Chapter 7: Finding What Works for You

Partner Book

There is an accompanying group supervision resource, developed by Ashley, on Structured Sessions in Group Supervision. It also contains a document to support setting expectations with dissertation students, Appendix A, which is discussed in Chapter 3.

1 About Us

1.1 Who we are

We are Dr Ashley Robertson and Dr Holly Neill, and we developed this resource while working together within the School of Psychology & Neuroscience at the University of Glasgow.

We both run group dissertation supervision (although in different ways!) and we developed this joint resource to help others who want to run group dissertation supervision. Through this book, we hope to provide some ideas of how you could incorporate group supervision in a way that works for you. You may or may not currently supervise in groups: either way, we will provide some ideas of activities you might want to try in group supervision, as well as make some suggestions about how you might want to structure group supervision.

Although we come from a background of Psychology, and there will be some references or literature referring to supervision in Psychology, we have kept this resource general and open, so that it could apply to dissertation supervision across many disciplines.

1.2 How to use the resource

This resource can be used however you want! Please feel free to use the information contained within it, to adapt it for your own uses, or to pass on to others.

This book draws on what we've both learned about group supervision and provides some resources for you to try out.

1.3 Further information

If you have any questions at all, or would like a workshop or talk in your department on Group Supervision for Dissertations please feel free to get in touch with Ashley.

It can be hard to evidence impact of resources like this, as there is no way to track if people are accessing it and using anything from it. If you find any part of this resource useful or end up using something from it in your own supervision, we would be **hugely grateful** to you for taking the time to let us know. We've set up a Microsoft Form which can be used to give some feedback.

2 Benefits (and challenges!) of Group Supervision

One of the biggest assumptions that we have come across is that Group Dissertation Supervision is only possible if all students work on the same project (e.g. looking at different variables).

However, this is not a requirement (and is not how we run our supervision!). In this chapter, we will cover different models to group supervision (including what we do), and why it can be beneficial to supervise dissertation students as a group, even if students are working on completely different projects.

2.1 Different models of Group Supervision

There are many different models of dissertation and, indeed, many different models of supervising dissertation students as a group.

Creaven et al. (2023) detail different models of undergraduate dissertation supervision in Psychology in their paper.

Thinking specifically about group supervision, these include:

- Collective Academic Supervision
  - Students meet only as a group and undertake independent (but similar) projects, supervised by the same supervisor
  - Example: Dautel (2020)
- Consortium model
  - Consists of multiple groups of students across different Universities collaborating on one protocol and supervised by supervisor in their University
  - Example: Button et al. (2020)
- Apprentice-Based Senior Thesis
  - Students collaborate together in small groups on one protocol; supervised by a single supervisor
  - Example: Mickey-Steinmetz & Reid (2019)

- Laddered Model
  - Students are separated into three-person teams, with each team consisting of three students with differing levels of expertise (one experienced, one mid-level and one new to the group)
  - Example: Detweiler-Bedell & Detweiler-Bedell (2019)
- "Cluster" projects
  - Two members of staff collaborate to supervise students (in groups as well as individually) on projects sharing a) a topic, b) a research question, c) methods or d) type of data analysis.
  - Example: Freeman et al. (2020)

There will be other models of supervision used, especially across different disciplines.

2.1.1 Our models of supervision

Each of us supervises both Undergraduate and Postgraduate Taught students. We use slightly different models of supervision to each other, although both are closest to the 'Collective Academic Supervision' model described by Creaven et al. (2023).

To provide some context, our Undergraduate supervision is for final year students who are on-campus, whereas our PGT supervision is for students who are completing their dissertation through Online Distance Learning (and are therefore based all over the world).

In this book, we will mainly discuss how we supervise for final year undergraduate students, as we have found it difficult to schedule group supervision for Online Distance Learning students due to working commitments and differing time zones. Saying this, our supervision approaches are not specific to undergraduate students and apply equally well to postgraduates.

Ashley's supervision model

Ashley holds a mixture of group and individual supervision, switching between the two on a weekly basis:

- Fortnightly group supervision (e.g. Weeks 1, 3, 5 and so on)
  - Each supervision is 'themed', with focus on skill development and covering challenges that are consistent across all projects
  - Resources are passed on to students: full breakdown of each session across two semesters can be found here
  - Each session scheduled for around 1 hour, although the final session is longer
- Individual supervision (e.g. Weeks 2, 4, 6 and so on)
  - An example of a 'Touching base' session

  - Individual sessions are dedicated time for students to ask questions, discuss project-specific challenges/concerns and identify priorities for progress
  - Actions noted for future sessions
  - Deadlines set using the 'joint deadlines document' (see Chapter 3)

Holly's supervision model

Holly holds group supervision sessions on a weekly basis. She splits this between two different types of group supervision sessions:

- 'Milestone' group sessions
  - Around three milestone sessions are held per semester, each consisting of collaborative activities
  - With larger groups (e.g. six or more), these are scheduled for around 1.5 hours each
  - Students are asked to complete activities in advance and during each milestone session
  - Examples of activities covered in milestone sessions are in Chapter 5
- Regular group supervision (or 'Touching Base' session)
  - Held on a weekly basis, in the weeks that there is no milestone session
  - Opportunity to catch up on progress, ask questions and plan progress
  - Actions noted for future sessions

2.2 Why Supervise Dissertations as a Group?

Historically, dissertations have been supervised one-on-one, in an 'expert' and 'apprentice' model (McCallin & Nayar, 2012). Group supervision can offer both peer and supervisor support, and can deepen learning by exposing students to varied theoretical and methodological perspectives (Nordentoft et al., 2013). Students can benefit from hearing varied points of view and being exposed to different research designs and topics. It can also be an efficient way to supervise (as there is no need to repeat information multiple times) and allows students to learn from the questions that they never thought to ask.

2.2.1 Feedback from students

Here is just some of the feedback that students who have been supervised through group supervision in our School have left about their experiences.

Feedback from students

Group meetings were “motivating”, “inspiring” and “comforting”
“Hearing other people’s ideas and perspectives was so helpful”
“It was so lovely to get to feel a part of the community”
“Excellent, would honestly recommend this format”

In general, students in our School report enjoying group supervision as it helps them to feel less isolated and they learn from their peers as well as their supervisor. It can also be an enjoyable experience!

2.2.2 Benefits for students

In our experience, group supervision has been beneficial for the students that we have supervised:

- Student wellbeing
  - In our School often the students won’t know their peers within their dissertation group. Working together can give valuable alternative perspectives and help students to connect with each other. This can help to facilitate feelings of connectedness among the cohort.
- Support each other
  - Peer support can be a useful result of students becoming familiar with each other through group supervision. This might be led by supervisors (e.g. as in Holly’s examples where students give feedback to each other) or can be organised by students themselves (e.g. Ashley’s students met as a group to practice setting up an interview together).
- Gain experience of how teams work
  - Working together in a group setting can provide students with an opportunity to work on a longer project with others. It can expose students to diverse perspectives, to develop an understanding of different roles within a team and to learn to balance both individual and group responsibilities.
- Develop transferable skills in collaboration
  - Working as part of a group enables students to develop key skills that are important for employers, such as communication skills, critical thinking, time management and negotiation.

2.2.3 Benefits for staff

There are also key benefits for staff in including group sessions within your supervision:

- Manage workload efficiently
  - Seeing students as a group, either alongside individual sessions or solely as a group, can reduce required contact time, easing pinch points in workload.
- Group together common queries and concerns
  - There are often similar questions and concerns, or information that is common to all projects. Supervising as a group can allow you to maintain a consistent message about expectations, and reduce time spent sharing the same information.
- Enjoy the group dynamic!
  - It is often a pleasant experience to see students develop and grow over the course of their dissertation, and this is no different with group supervision. It is enjoyable to see students supporting and learning from each other throughout the year.

2.3 Challenges of Group Supervision

It is also important to note that Group Supervision is not perfect and without any issues! Nordentoft et al. (2013) developed the Collective Academic Supervision model. In a subsequent paper, the same team identified three main challenges with supervising students collectively (Wichman-Hansen et al., 2015):

- supporting diverse groups of students to contribute equally
- striking an optimal balance between passing on information and involving students in learning
- determining how to support the growth of students' evaluative and analytical skills

In our experience, some of these can be addressed by not requiring that students work together on shared projects (e.g. social loafing is less of an issue in individual projects, even if students are supervised as a group), and others can be addressed by planning interactive activities for the sessions that are focused on skill development. Wichman-Hansen et al., (2015) suggest that setting expectations are very important, although future research is needed in terms of supervisors' experiences of group supervision, as well as better understanding different ways of interacting in these contexts.

Sometimes, one concern that staff have is that some groups are quieter than others, and that group supervision can feel a bit 'flat' or require the supervisor to constantly facilitate discussion. This is one of the reasons that Ashley has a clear theme and structure for each group session. It can often take a little time for quieter groups to warm up, especially when there are no

pre-established relationships. Try not to worry if groups are a little quiet at the start - this usually eases up over time and formerly quiet groups will often suddenly have lots to discuss after a few weeks/months.

3 Getting Set up for the Year Ahead

It can be useful to set up a few things in advance of starting supervision, as it can help make the process of group supervision smoother and more efficient. It also means that students will know where to access information, and better understand what they can expect during supervision (and what is expected of them).

3.1 Transparency and communication

In our supervision, we've found that it can be particularly helpful to be transparent with students about why we include certain tasks as part of supervision (e.g. peer review, practice talks). You'll see that for each of our examples of group supervision sessions in Chapter 5, we provide a rationale to share with students for this reason. This transparency also applies to getting set up for the year, so that students know in advance what they can expect during the process of conducting their dissertation.

This can be beneficial in multiple ways:

- Setting expectations and being clear about what supervision will look like can be particularly helpful for students experiencing anxiety or those who are neurodivergent. Being clear and upfront in advance, without students asking for it, can help students know what to expect
- Being transparent and open can help to establish trust as part of the supervisory relationship, which can make students more likely to open up if they are experiencing difficulties
- Communicating expectations can help promote accountability and support students to track their progress over a longer piece of work

As well as being transparent about what supervision entails, we find it is also important to be open about times that we have experienced challenges. For example, we both tell students about times that we have found something difficult, or ways in which we struggled as students, in an effort to normalise the experience of writing a dissertation (which can be daunting!).

3.2 Practical resources

To support our supervision, we've developed some practical resources that are linked below. Please feel free to adapt any of these and use them however might be useful for you.

3.2.1 Setting expectations document

The purpose of the 'setting expectations' document is to explicitly detail the supervision process for both students. They have been well-received, but the students (so far!) who seem to find it most useful are a) international students and b) neurodivergent students.

This document gives students an overview of:

- expectations (both of students and of the supervisor)
- structure and topics covered in supervision sessions
- setting deadlines and how these will be managed
- how we will communicate (e.g. teams/email)
- feedback
  - when feedback can be expected
  - what feedback will look like
  - how to ask for specific feedback
- peer review
- future aspirations

It can be presented in whichever format works best for you. The full document is Appendix A of Structured Sessions in Group Supervision. That book also provides PDF versions of the document for final year undergraduate and online distance learning postgraduate students, in the 'Setting expectations with students' section of its Overview page.

3.2.2 Shared file structure (e.g. on Teams/OneDrive)

As part of getting set up for the year, it is helpful to create a shared file structure - for example on Teams or OneDrive - where you and your students can share resources, drafts and feedback. How this is organised, and who can see what, will depend on your students and on your supervision style. Below we describe two approaches, one from each of us. They differ in how the folders are organised (by task or by student) and in who has access to what.

Open structure, organised by task (Holly)

Holly organises folders by task, with a subfolder for each student. For example:

1. Proposals & Ethics

a. Student A
b. Student B
c. Student C
d. Student D

2. Introductions

a. Student A
b. Student B
c. Student C
d. Student D

… and so on.

Linking to the ideas of openness and transparency noted above, Holly tends to grant access to all folders for all students in her group. This is useful to facilitate activities like peer review, feedback and discussion. For example, after each student reviews a peer's Introduction draft, they then lead a feedback discussion with input from Holly, which opens into a broader discussion with the whole group. Let's say a peer reviewer has noted that the logical flow between paragraphs could be smoother in places: we discuss how to achieve this and then Holly can point to a student's work which did this effectively, and ask if they are happy for their peer to have a look.

Holly's students have fed back that this is helpful and motivating to see how the group are progressing and to get peer support like this. However, it is important to be mindful of cases where this completely open file structure may be less helpful for certain students. For example, if one student has faced significant delays or challenging circumstances, you may judge that it is better to create private folders for each student to avoid unhelpful and demotivating social comparisons.

Individual linked folders, organised by student (Ashley)

Ashley's approach is closer to the private-folder option described above. She creates one folder per student on her university OneDrive and shares it individually with that student's university account, so only they can open it. Each folder contains the same five subfolders, and students can add their own. Items that students choose to share with the group sit separately, in the Teams channel:

```
[Student's individual folder]     OneDrive: private to student and supervisor
|-- Proposal
|-- Ethics
|-- Data
|-- Analysis
|-- Dissertation Drafts
`-- (additional folders added by the student)
```

```
[Teams channel]                    Teams SharePoint site: shared with the whole group
`-- Items students choose to share
```

Students use their folder for the work they want feedback on, and keep their data and analysis files there throughout, so that Ashley has access to everything related to the dissertation. Other versions of their work can be kept elsewhere. Students are asked to upload to the folder themselves. If something is sent another way or forgotten, Ashley adds a copy to the folder when she receives it, so that the folder is always a complete record. The folders do not send alerts, so students message Ashley on Teams when something has been added. Feedback is returned as in-text comments with a short global summary, and the order in which drafts are reviewed is tracked in the joint deadlines document.

Each folder has an expiry date set around graduation. At that point the student loses access, but nothing is deleted and Ashley retains it.

Ashley introduced individual folders for two reasons. First, some students feel their work must be polished before anyone else sees it, and a private folder means a draft can reach the supervisor at whatever stage it is in, which is intended to lower the barrier to sharing work in progress. Second, the supervisor needs access to everything related to the dissertation, including data, without relying on students to send it. This approach is new for 2026-27 and has not yet been evaluated.

Sharing with the wider group is selective and builds over the year. Students are encouraged to start with low-stakes items such as bullet-point introductions, move on to summaries of their analyses, and later share the slides for their final presentation They can also peer review each other's Discussion sections if they wish. The student-facing description of this process is in Appendix A of Structured Sessions in Group Supervision.

Choosing between the two

The two approaches rest on different assumptions. An open structure assumes that seeing peers' work is motivating and helps to normalise drafts that are still rough. Individual folders assume that, for some students, being visible to peers is a barrier, and that sharing selectively is an easier place to start.

The approach that a supervisor takes is likely to depend on the group: how well students know each other, how confident they are, and whether anyone is struggling with progress or circumstances.

3.2.3 Shared OneNote

Holly also links to a shared OneNote notebook from her group's Teams channel. This creates a collaborative space where students can share notes on literature they find; outlines of e.g. their Introduction plan to discuss with the group; and a weekly progress log. This log invites

students to keep a note each week of what they have been working on, what questions they have, and what their goal is for the coming week. This can help keep students focused and motivated, and also helps the supervisor to keep track of what multiple different students are working on.

3.2.4 Joint deadlines document

Ashley uses a deadline document for each cohort of supervisees. This details deadlines (these tend to be soft deadlines, but others might decide to do hard deadlines) and also notes when each draft was received and when feedback was returned.

It can help keep on top of a) where each student is in the process, b) the order in which sections are received, and c) allows students to know where their draft is in the 'queue'. Students are able to view the spreadsheet but they are not able to edit it, meaning they can't change a deadline without discussion.

Ashley finds it helps students to be accountable for when they plan to submit drafts. It also helps to reduce unrealistic expectations in terms of return times. It is important to be flexible and be clear with students that the aim is to support them, rather than to constrain them unnecessarily.

Examples of deadline documents:

- Undergraduate final year deadline document
- Online Distance learning PGT deadline document

4 Different Types of Supervision Sessions

We both split our supervision into two types of sessions: unstructured or 'touching base' sessions and structured sessions.

Although these look different for both of us, our supervision contains both types.

4.1 'Touching Base' Sessions

These tend to be sessions where students might bring along their questions and update you on their progress. There are many different options!

Ashley has these as individual sessions, held fortnightly whereas Holly has them as weekly group sessions (in the weeks where she does not hold a structured session).

Other staff members in our School schedule drop-in sessions or have specific office hours for students. Others have these based on projects, putting students into pairs or smaller groups.

4.1.1 Things you might want to cover in a 'Touching Base' session

These types of sessions are mainly about catching up and seeing how the projects are going. They are an opportunity to answer questions and plan future steps.

- How is progress going?

- How is the student finding their project?
- Do students have any concerns?
  - Ethics
  - Recruitment & Data collection
  - Analysis
  - Writing
- What questions does the student have?
- What is the student hoping to achieve in the next week/fortnight/by the next session?
- Record-keeping (e.g. outcomes/actions from the supervision session)

4.2 Structured Sessions

In the next Chapter, we will share some worked examples of the types of activities we use in our structured sessions. For each, we'll share example text of communicating the activity rationale to students, an accompanying resource for students, and some of our tips for supervisors on how to run each group session. Feel free to use any of these as they are, adapt them to the needs of your students, or perhaps the examples will inspire some of your own new ideas!

Before we made this joint resource, Ashley also developed a separate book detailing each structured session that she runs, with an overview of what's covered for each one, along with links to resources. If you would like to take a bit of a 'deep dive' into how these sessions might be structured, you are very welcome to access this too. You can find this in Structured Sessions in Group Supervision.

5 Examples of Group Supervision Sessions

5.1 Lightning Talks

Written by: Dr Holly Neill

Lightning talks are short-form presentations (typically 5 minutes maximum) that challenge presenters to summarise their ideas very concisely. The short duration makes Lightning Talks perfect for incorporating into group sessions, and this can be done at any stage in the dissertation. Here is an example of supporting students to clarify their dissertation plans by giving a Proposal Lightning Talk early in the process.

5.1.1 Rationale to share with students

Here is how I explain the rationale behind this activity to my students:

Example Rationale for Lightning Talks

As discussed, in next week's meeting we will have short (5 min max) "Lightning Talks" on everyone's proposals. This format is now quite common at conferences, as a way to concisely convey the key take-away messages of a study, allowing interested audience members to discuss more details with you afterwards.
Some of the benefits of you doing this for your proposal are:

- You clarify your key arguments/decisions by having to communicate them concisely
- You can get informal feedback from the group before finalising your proposal document
- You practice skills in presenting that you will use in your course and in future work settings
- You get to see how others in the group are approaching issues that could inform your thinking/approach to your own study

I have shared a template PowerPoint. It's 5 slides and I would challenge you to be as concise as you can. Once you have prepared your proposal document, you can pick out the key points and add them to the slides. Remember that this is for informal feedback from the group - we're not expecting you to get everything right first time and we will be a super supportive and encouraging audience!

5.1.2 Accompanying resource

This activity has an accompanying five-slide PowerPoint template, into which students add the key points from their proposal. The original template is no longer available, so you may wish to create your own along similar lines. Depending on their course, this may be one of the first presentations that students have given during their time at university, and they are only at the start of their dissertation. Therefore, I find it helpful to provide this scaffolding to help ease any nerves.

5.1.3 Running the group meeting

In terms of the practicalities of running this group meeting, I ask students to share their slides in advance (for example, in a shared Teams folder) to allow a quick set up and smooth running on the day. I explain to students that – similar to many conferences – I will give them a 1-minute warning and then a "time up" signal.

We have time for questions after each Lightning Talk. It might be the first time that students are audience members for this type of academic talk, so it can be helpful to provide some guidance at the start of the session on what types of questions they might want to ask. Being mindful that some students can feel nervous about this type of talk, I offer them the option to stay standing up for questions or to rejoin the group for a more informal discussion around the table if they prefer.

I like to aim for a supportive and encouraging tone in this session. I emphasis that this is about getting some practice and helpful feedback, not about getting everything perfect. To help create a positive atmosphere, I like to light-heartedly challenge my students to "win" at being the most supportive audience: lots of smiling and nodding!

It can be good to finish this session by inviting students to crowdsource their tips for giving this type of talk, based on what they learned from their experience as a presenter and an audience member. Afterwards, this can be a great stage to encourage students to reflect on their skills development: we provide some guidance on how to support this in Chapter 6.

5.2 Presenting an Outline for a written section

Written by: Dr Holly Neill

One area that I wanted to support my students to improve was developing a cohesive and persuasive overall argument in the Introduction as to why their research question merits investigation. To support this, I invite students to produce a bullet point outline of their Introduction plan, focusing on convincing the reader of their study rationale. In a structured group meeting, students then talk the group through their outline. This offers the opportunity to clarify their ideas by concisely articulating them to the group, and to receive constructure

feedback on areas for enhancement from their peers. For example, as naive readers/listeners, the group may highlight a gap in the logical progression of an overall narrative.

While this example focuses on the Introduction and rationale, the same approach can be used for any section. For example, it may be useful for constructing a Discussion plan and targeting any areas you feel that students have found trickier, such as supporting their study limitations with evidence.

5.2.1 Rationale to share with students

Here is an example of explaining the rationale behind this activity to your students:

Example Rationale for Outline of a Written Section

It's time to start planning for drafting the Introduction. For next week, I'd like you to prepare a bullet point outline of your Introduction section, where each bullet point briefly summarises one key step in your overall argument to convince your reader why this study should be done. You will share this outline and, at our meeting, talk the group through the outline for some feedback. Some of the benefits of doing this task are:
You will organise your thoughts and start to build a coherent narrative for your Introduction draft that covers all key arguments.
You will gain feedback from me and your peers on the logical progression of your outline, including constructive suggestions for improvements.
You will be able to use your finished outline to break down the task of drafting an Introduction into manageable chunks.
You will practice clear and confident verbal communication by articulating your ideas to the group, which is an important skill for the future.
I have shared an example bullet point outline for the Introduction of one of my papers. This is simply one example of how this might look. Don't feel that yours has to follow a similar structure: this is just an example of focusing on the logical progression of key arguments.

5.2.2 Accompanying resource

I share a one-page resource with students on outlining an Introduction argument. Following the group meeting, I also share an Introduction progress tracker, where they can insert each key argument/paragraph and log their progress on e.g. gathering literature to support it, making notes, drafting and redrafting. Students have found this helpful to get over the daunting blank page when they begin drafting, as they can break the task down into manageable chunks.

5.2.3 Running the group meeting

On a practical note, it is helpful if students share their written outlines in advance: for example, I create an "Introduction Outlines" tab on our shared OneNote with pages named for each student.

In the structured group meeting, each student in turn talks through their proposed outline, while the rest of the group listens out for whether the content, ordering and linking make sense to someone reading/listening for the first time. This forms the basis for useful wider group discussions on how to structure an Introduction, how to make links between ideas etc.

This is also a useful session to take some time to discuss how different students approach writing, including what they have found helpful or tricky in the past. This creates an opportunity to crowdsource some top tips, and for students to gain comfort knowing that they are not alone in finding some aspect of writing challenging. This can open nicely into a wider group discussion around issues raised, e.g. overcoming perfectionism.

5.3 Peer Review

Written by: Dr. Holly Neill

Peer review offers students a useful opportunity to view written work through the lens of a marker, engaging with the Intended Learning Outcomes of the assessment to identify strengths and recommend areas for improvement. Reviewing a peer's draft can encourage students to think critically about aspects of writing that they want to emulate or avoid in their own work, and those who engage more critically have been shown to go on to earn higher grades (Yalch et al., 2019).

Dissertation students can engage in peer review of all sorts of materials: not only drafts, as in this example, but also proposals, ethics applications, materials etc. Peer feedback can be written and/or verbal: in this example, students share written feedback on a draft before a group meeting where this forms the basis for group discussion.

5.3.1 Rationale to share with students

Here is an example of explaining the rationale behind this activity to your students:

> **Example Rationale for Peer Review**
>
> Congratulations on completing your Introduction drafts, what a great milestone! As discussed, we're going to use this as an opportunity for some peer review. The advantage of engaging in this peer review task include:

- You will benefit from added feedback on your draft, not just from me but also from a peer

- The evidence shows that the process of reviewing others' written work helps you to then improve your own
- You will build experience of how teams work together to produce output (not just in research but all sorts of workplaces)
- You will also develop important transferable skills in giving constructive feedback (both written and verbal)

I have shared a peer review form with some questions for you to reflect on as you read your peer's work this week. Remember that this is an opportunity to support each other by identifying what is already working well, what could be improved and importantly how it could be improved. Next week we will have a chance to discuss our feedback and crowdsource ideas to help with any common tricky areas.

In this message to students, I will also list who will be reviewing whose work. You can consider what will support the most useful feedback (for example, grouping together similar methods) as well as avoiding any pitfalls (such as not grouping students together who are working closely on shared pair or group projects, to prevent unintentional plagiarism).

5.3.2 Accompanying resource

I provide a peer review form for Introduction drafts. The original form is no longer available to link to, but it is helpful to provide some structure and prompts for students to reflect on as they read and review (for example, what is already working well, what could be improved, and how it could be improved). Feel free to create your own form to suit your own Intended Learning Outcomes or perhaps target common problematic areas of drafts that you have seen repeatedly.

5.3.3 Running the group meeting

In terms of set up, I create a shared space (e.g. a Teams folder) where students upload their written feedback ahead of the meeting (say, 24 hours before). So far, I have always shared my own feedback comments for each student here as well, facilitating transparency. However, depending on your group of students each year, if there are any issues then you may consider it more appropriate to send feedback individually.

As with any interactive session, I like to set a supportive tone and start by reminding the group that all discussion should be encouraging and constructive. I have always been genuinely impressed by the quality of written feedback in my students' peer reviews, with a consistent

encouraging tone and concrete, constructive suggestions for enhancement. This in turn forms the basis for a very productive and supportive group session: for example, it can be useful for students to share experiences of what they found trickier in writing their drafts, to know that they are not alone.

In practice, during this meeting, I facilitate a group discussion focused on each student's draft in turn, initially based on input from me and their peer reviewer (on what is working well and what areas they can focus on refining), then opening into a broader discussion about how some of these improvements can be achieved in any strong discussion (involving all group members). Where relevant, it can be encouraging to point out strong aspects of students' work that are a good example: for instance, if one student has found it difficult to create logical links between paragraphs and another student's work has good examples of achieving this.

5.4 Evaluation of a Discussion section

Written by Dr Ashley Robertson (jointly developed with Dr. Wil Toivo)

In my experience, one of the areas that students find quite tricky to write for their dissertation is the Discussion section. It is also the only section that students do not receive feedback on from supervisors (in our School, students get feedback on Introduction, Methods and Results only). It can also be quite difficult for students to demonstrate more complex evaluation skills.

To support this, my colleague and I developed some materials to support students when writing a Discussion section, highlighting key issues that we often see. These were designed for use in labs for our research methods course, but we have since also used them in our group dissertation meetings. As we had had instances of students copying examples and only changing a few words, we chose a topic that was very different (**postgraduate students' confidence in surviving the zombie apocalypse**), in order to encourage generalisation of the skills learned. To support this, we used GenAI to provide the basis for the 'not so good' examples.

5.4.1 Rationale to share with students

Here is an example of explaining the rationale behind this activity to your students:

> **Example Rationale for Evaluation of the Discussion**
>
> In the next session, we are going to do some activities to support you when you come to writing your Discussion. I have provided three different 'not so good examples' from a Discussion section: what points can you identify? In the group meeting, we will discuss what you found. We will then look at some better (not perfect!) examples and discuss

these too. Finally, we will identify some actions that you can take to support the writing of your Discussion section.
Some of the benefits of doing this task are:

- You will be able to identify common mistakes that are made when writing Discussion sections
- You will benefit from the wider discussion of the group around what staff look for and do not look for in a Discussion section
- You will identify clear and actionable points that you can apply to your own writing of the Discussion section
- You will practice discussing your ideas with your peers and staff, which is an important skill for the future

I have shared three 'not so good' excerpts from a Discussion section. For each, identify some issues for each. We will then see what everyone in the group identified once we meet.

5.4.2 Accompanying resource

Here is a copy of the excerpts we use for the Discussion evaluation activity. This contains both notes for staff as well as the activity itself.

There are three particular aspects of Discussion sections that we are looking at in this activity:

- Excerpt 1: Linking findings to the evidence base
- Excerpt 2: Limitations
- Excerpt 3: Implications

Please feel free to adapt the activities or the notes in a way that works for you in your own supervision.

5.4.3 Running the group meeting

To set this up, I create a thread on Teams (I have a shared Teams channel just for my dissertation students and me) and post the excerpts along with the rationale. This allows students time to prepare if they prefer. The excerpts are very short, so if students don't have time to read through them before the meeting, this is not a problem as I can give everyone a few minutes to do it there and then. I have included the excerpts as well as some notes for staff for this activity under 'Accompanying resource' above.

I usually have printed copies of each of the excerpts (both 'not so good' and 'better'), so we can see them. We go through the 'not so good' (1A, 2A and 3A) together and I facilitate a discussion on this. Once these issues have been identified, I show the students the 'better' examples (1B, 2B and 3B) one at a time. For each one, I give them a minute to read it and then we have a discussion about what was better about this example. There may also be some problems they identify too, as these are not designed to be perfect.

Then, I ask each student to identify one thing that they've learned from the session to incorporate into their own Discussion section. I then ask them to write this down and commit to this as an action when they come to write or edit their Discussion.

5.5 Conference Presentation

Written by Dr Ashley Robertson

It is important for students to develop skills in presenting. In our School, we hold a conference for students one week after they have submitted their dissertation, in order to help support these skills.

Students have the opportunity to present in one of the following ways:

- Scientific presentation
- Lightning talk
- Bright Club/Pint of Science talks
- Panel discussion
- Written Science Communication piece

The talks and discussions are presented live in the conference, and the written contributions collated together and sent out. Most students choose to present live at the conference.

Although this is a very supportive experience, students can find presenting a bit daunting. To help, I hold a practice session for those students working with me, to provide them with an opportunity to practice their talk before the conference itself. It also enables those presenting at the British Psychological Society Scottish Branch Undergraduate conference to have an additional opportunity to practice speaking in front of others.

5.5.1 Rationale to share with students

Example Rationale for Conference presentation

In our final group session together, we are going to hold a practice session for your contribution to the Level 4 undergraduate conference on [DATE]. This will be both a celebration for completing your dissertations as well as a practice conference presentation.

The advantages of taking part in this conference practice session include:

- Having an opportunity to practice in a safe space. If doing a talk, you can run through this in front of the group. If you have chosen a debate, I can ask you some practice questions. If you have chosen a written contribution, you can outline what you are planning to cover.
- You will have the opportunity to practice responding to questions from the audience, which will help prepare you for the conference
- You will receive feedback from me (and hopefully each other!) on your talk/debate/outline, helping to refine your contribution
- Presenting your work is a highly sought-after skill that employers value
- It gives us the opportunity to come together after all your hard work on the dissertation and celebrate your achievement together!

In preparation, please let me know in advance which type of talk or other contribution you are doing in the conference. We will have a slightly longer session than usual, to make sure that we have plenty of time and aren't rushed.

5.5.2 Accompanying resource

In a previous group session, I will have shared some of my tips on presenting. I share these again with the students in advance of the group session.

5.5.3 Running the group meeting

I usually book a teaching room so that students can present on the equipment, as they would in the conference. The length of time depends on the number of students in the group, but I tend to aim for around 1.5 hours. I also print out timing notices (e.g. 2 minutes to go) as these are used at the conference.

Students will be asked in advance whether they are doing a talk (and if so, which kind), if they are part of a panel discussion or if they are submitting a written piece. They are asked to either bring their slides (if relevant) on a USB stick or to send them to me in advance. I log on to the computer and then we establish an order that people want to go in. I reiterate that this is not supposed to be a scary experience, and is to help support them for future presentations. I encourage them to ask each other questions.

Talks/presentations

For any talks, I explain that I will a) keep time, b) will show signs to indicate how long they have left (this is something that I find throws students and practising it helps prepare them

for the conference) and c) will write some feedback for them. I will also ask a question if the other students don't come up with any.

Panel discussion

For students taking part in a panel discussion, I will ask them some questions on their research project (e.g. what motivated them to do this topic, what their most important recommendation would be, what they would change if they had to run the project again) and we will have a discussion about the research. I will pass on any feedback or suggestions I have for them.

Written piece

For students doing a written piece, I will ask the student to talk through what they are planning (e.g. a blog post) and then ask questions about what they have planned. I will also give feedback on what they have planned so far.

After everyone has presented, we have a small celebration (I usually bring cakes) and see how they are all feeling about submitting their dissertation.

6 Employability and Transferable Skills

One important aspect of supervising dissertations is to prepare students for their next steps post-graduation. Rather than the specific topic of the dissertation, in general employers and postgraduate admissions teams are looking for the transferable skills that students have developed through this experience. Group supervision can offer opportunities for students to develop transferable skills that can be more challenging to achieve in traditional one-to-one sessions, for example in teamwork, collaboration and leadership. These skills are amongst the top requested skills in job adverts (Bennet, 2002).

Often, while we as supervisors can appreciate the range of transferable skills our students have developed by graduation, they themselves can find it harder to recognise and articulate these skills. To tackle this gap, we can provide support for students to reflect on their skill development throughout the dissertation. Students can then look back on their reflective skills log to help articulate and evidence transferable skills in applications and interviews (McCallum & Casey, 2017).

As always, it is important to clearly articulate the rationale for asking students to engage in this task. For example:

> "At certain key stages in the dissertation, I will be sharing some prompts for you to reflect on and record. Some benefits you will get from engaging in this type of reflection about your learning and skill development journey include:
> Developing critical thinking skills and meta-cognition, which help you to do well both on your course and in future work settings
> Creating a log of your skills journey while carrying out a significant piece of independent research, so you can look back and see how far you have come
> Identifying how particular activities have developed skills that you can clearly communicate in future job/course applications and interviews
> To help with this final point of articulating which skills you have demonstrated at different stages of the dissertation project, I'll be asking you to consider how specific activities, experiences and skills relate to your transferable skills. You may find it helpful to refer to the University's Graduate Attributes framework, which summarises the key qualities and transferable skills that you develop during your time at university and that you can communicate to potential employers / postgraduate programme leads."

This type of reflective practice may feel alien to students at first. However, rather than being an innate quality, the ability to critically reflect can be learned given appropriate support,

e.g. in the form of scaffolding (Coulson & Harvey, 2013). For example, Holly provides the following prompts after each milestone collaborative activity (see Chapter 5):

> "Thinking about the experience of [preparing and delivering your Lightning Talk, including discussing any questions and feedback] …
> How did you feel about this task? (You may wish to think about when you first took it on vs. after you had completed it.)
> What did you find challenging and why?
> What transferable skills/Graduate Attributes do you feel you developed or enhanced through this experience?
> How would you use your [Lightning Talk] experience as evidence of these skills for e.g. an application?"

The collaborative activities can push students outside of their comfort zone, for example by tackling nerves in public speaking or taking on the role of reviewer, for which students often feel underqualified (Mulder et al., 2014). Therefore, inviting them to reflect on how they felt about the task before and after completing it can help them to build confidence in their abilities and supports a growth mindset, in which students believe that intellectual ability can be developed (Yeager & Dweck, 2020). For example, one student reflected on their increase in confidence after the Lightning Talk:

"When I first found out about the task I was a little apprehensive as I had not had an opportunity to do a presentation since school [...] When it came to be my turn, I was a little nervous [...] Afterwards, I felt proud of myself for being able to do it"

Reflecting on the challenges of this task, they continued that:

"I found it quite challenging to be concise [...] so I had to really consider what were the most important parts"

This reflection then supported them to articulate the graduate attributes they had demonstrated through this particular activity, for example:

"I enhanced my skills in being a *critical thinker* as I had to be critical and evaluate what information was the most relevant to include in my presentation. [...] I became an *effective communicator* as I had to articulate my rationale and study in an understandable way for people who had not read the research"

By supporting dissertation students to keep this type of reflective skills log, we can build their confidence and help them establish a catalogue of evidence that they can draw on to provide concrete and specific examples that evidence their skills in applications and interviews. This approach pairs well with group supervision, which offers unique opportunities for students to enhance their communication, teamwork and interpersonal skills.

7 Finding what works for you

We wanted to end the book by thinking about how to find what works for you. We hope that this book gives you some ideas for trying out group supervision in some way, although we aren't suggesting that you do exactly the same as us. You might choose to have only group supervision from now on, or you may decide it's not for you at all. Others might choose to have some sort of combination of group and individual.

Something to be aware of is that group supervision might not work perfectly first time - it can involve a bit of trial and error. Both of our supervision models have evolved over time and we reflect on what works and what doesn't, tweaking what we do each year. It can be a challenging (and rewarding) process. Sometimes, group supervision can depend on each specific group of students - some things might work with one group but not with another. You might also have to make exceptions for particular students at times. Our main suggestion would be to be responsive to how supervision feels, and don't feel that you can't make changes at any point.

We have included some concrete suggestions for sessions in Chapter 5. Please feel free to use as much or little of these as you wish, and to adapt them or pass them on to others. These are designed to give some ideas for what you could do in group supervision, but is not meant to be prescriptive. There are likely to also be examples of excellent practice within your own University and Department/School.

If you are struggling to get started, it can sometimes be helpful to think about one thing that you notice that would be good to work on with students (e.g. could the rationale of their project be clearer, or evaluation?). Designing some sort of activity around that key aspect of their work may then be a good place to start off!

We would love to hear from you if you end up using any of the book in your practice, would like to discuss things with us further or have some suggestions for how we could adapt the book in the future!

If you would like to get in contact, feel free to email Ashley.

As mentioned in Chapter 1, we've set up a Microsoft Form which can be used to give some feedback if you've used any of the resource.